

Hands-on Workshop on Research Work

Writing Background and Formulating Research Problem

Bijay Lal Pradhan

Tribhuvan University

02/10/2026

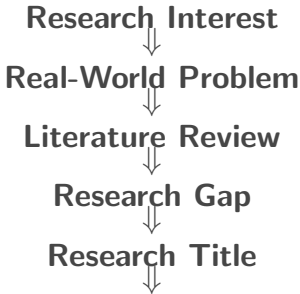
Training Objectives

Session 2: Learning Objectives

By the end of this session, participants will be able to:

1. Explain the purpose and importance of the **background of the study**.
2. Identify the major components of a strong **research background**.
3. Organize background information from **broad context to specific research issue**.
4. Use relevant literature and evidence to support statements in the background.
5. Distinguish between a **research topic, background, and research problem**.
6. Formulate a clear and researchable **research problem statement**.
7. Connect the research problem with the **research gap and research objectives**.
8. Write a preliminary background and problem statement for specific research topic.

Session 2: From Research Title to Research Problem



Background of the Study

What is happening and why does it matter?

Research Problem

What specific problem requires investigation?

Research Questions / Objectives

What is the Background of the Study?

Definition

The background of the study provides the **context and evidence** needed to understand:

- ▶ what the broader issue is,
- ▶ what is currently happening,
- ▶ why the issue is important,
- ▶ what previous studies have found,
- ▶ what remains unclear or insufficiently studied, and
- ▶ why the proposed study is needed.

Simple Idea

Background explains the journey toward the research problem.

Background is NOT the Research Problem

Background of the Study

Provides context

Explains what is happening

Uses evidence and literature

Moves from broad to specific

Builds justification

Research Problem

Identifies the specific issue

Explains what is wrong, unknown, or unresolved

Synthesizes evidence into a researchable problem

Focuses on the central issue

Provides the reason for conducting the study

Remember

The background **leads the reader to the problem**; it is not simply a collection of information.

What Should the Background Answer?

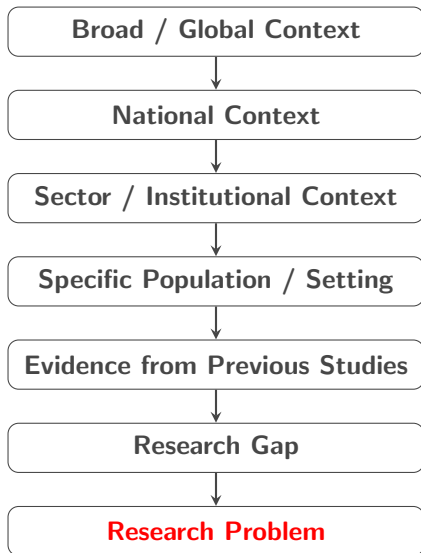
A well-written background should gradually answer:

1. **What is the issue?**
2. **What is happening in this area?**
3. **Why is the issue important?**
4. **What do previous studies tell us?**
5. **What is still missing, unclear, or problematic?**
6. **Who or what is affected?**
7. **Why is further research needed?**

Writing Principle

Each paragraph should move the reader **closer to the research problem**.

The Funnel Approach to Writing Background



Example: Applying the Funnel Approach

Broad Context

Digital transformation is changing how governments deliver public services.



National / Institutional Context

Governments are increasingly providing public services through digital platforms.



Specific Issue

However, citizens may differ in their ability to access and effectively use these services.



Evidence

Previous studies have identified factors as digital literacy, accessibility, trust, and service quality.



Research Problem

The factors influencing citizens' access to digital public services require further investigation in the selected context.

Basic Structure of a Research Background

A practical background can be organized into:

1. **Introduce the broad issue**
2. **Explain the current situation**
3. **Present relevant evidence**
4. **Narrow the discussion to the study context**
5. **Discuss previous research**
6. **Identify what remains unresolved**
7. **Establish the need for the study**
8. **Lead to the research problem**

Writing Logic

Context → Evidence → Issue → Gap → Need for Research

Paragraph-by-Paragraph Structure

- Paragraph 1** Introduce the broad topic and establish the general context.
- Paragraph 2** Explain the current situation using evidence and statistics.
- Paragraph 3** Narrow the discussion to the country, sector, institution, or population.
- Paragraph 4** Discuss what previous studies have found.
- Paragraph 5** Identify limitations, inconsistencies, or missing evidence.
- Paragraph 6** Explain why the issue requires further investigation.
- Paragraph 7** Lead directly to the research problem and proposed study.

How Much Background is Enough?

There is no fixed number of paragraphs for every study.

The appropriate length depends on:

- ▶ complexity of the research topic,
- ▶ availability of relevant evidence,
- ▶ level of the research,
- ▶ disciplinary conventions,
- ▶ scope of the study, and
- ▶ requirements of the institution or journal.

Practical Rule

Do not write background simply to make it long.

Every paragraph should contribute to understanding the problem.

Writing with Evidence

Avoid making important claims without evidence.

Weak Statement

Digital public services have become very important in modern government.

Evidence-Based Statement

Recent evidence indicates that digital technologies are increasingly being integrated into public service delivery and citizen interaction.

Good Practice

Use appropriate sources to support important claims, especially statistics, trends, relationships, and statements about previous research. (citation is required to state these statements)

What Types of Evidence Can Be Used?

Quantitative Evidence

- ▶ Population statistics
- ▶ Survey findings
- ▶ Administrative data
- ▶ Economic indicators
- ▶ Institutional reports
- ▶ Trends over time

Qualitative / Documentary Evidence

- ▶ Previous research
- ▶ Policy documents
- ▶ Government reports
- ▶ Laws and regulations
- ▶ Institutional documents
- ▶ Interviews / case evidence

Key Principle

Use evidence that is **relevant, credible, and appropriate for the claim being made.**

Do Not Turn the Background into a Literature Dump

Instead: Synthesize

Group studies according to:

- ▶ common findings,
- ▶ contrasting findings,
- ▶ themes,
- ▶ methods,
- ▶ populations,
- ▶ contexts, and
- ▶ limitations.

Think

What does the literature collectively tell us?

What is a Research Problem?

Research Problem

A research problem is a specific issue, difficulty, knowledge gap, inconsistency, or unanswered question that requires systematic investigation.

A research problem may arise from:

- ▶ a real-world problem,
- ▶ insufficient evidence,
- ▶ contradictory findings,
- ▶ an unexplored population,
- ▶ an unexplored geographical context,
- ▶ a methodological limitation,
- ▶ an overlooked variable, or
- ▶ a theoretical or conceptual uncertainty.

Research Problem vs. Research Gap

Research Problem

What issue needs attention?

May arise from practice or theory

Can be observed in the real world

Explains why the issue matters

Provides the central problem

Research Gap

What is missing from existing knowledge?

Usually identified through literature review

Concerns limitations in existing evidence

Explains what previous research has not adequately addressed

Helps justify the need for the proposed study

Connection

Research Problem + Evidence of Gap → Justification for the Study

Types of Research Problems

1. **Practical Problem**

A problem occurring in practice or society.

2. **Knowledge Problem**

Insufficient understanding or evidence.

3. **Empirical Problem**

Existing findings are incomplete or inconsistent.

4. **Contextual Problem**

Evidence exists elsewhere but is limited in the selected population or setting.

5. **Methodological Problem**

Previous studies have important design or measurement limitations.

6. **Theoretical Problem**

Existing theories do not adequately explain the phenomenon.

From Real-World Problem to Research Problem

Real-World Observation

Citizens experience difficulties using digital public services.



Possible Explanation

Limited digital literacy, accessibility, trust, service quality, or infrastructure.



Researchable Problem

There is insufficient evidence about the factors associated with citizens' access to digital public services in the selected context.



Research Question

What factors are associated with citizens' access to digital public services?

What is a Problem Statement?

The problem statement is a concise explanation of:

1. What is happening?
2. What should be happening?
3. What is the difference or problem?
4. Who or what is affected?
5. What evidence demonstrates the problem?
6. What is not adequately known?
7. Why does the problem require investigation?

Simple Formula

Current Situation + Evidence + Problem + Gap + Need for Study

A Simple Problem Statement Structure

1. **Context**

What is the broader situation?

2. **Problem**

What difficulty, inconsistency, or uncertainty exists?

3. **Evidence**

What evidence shows that the problem exists?

4. **Gap**

What is not sufficiently known or addressed?

5. **Consequence**

Why does the problem matter?

6. **Need**

Why is research required?

Example: Weak vs. Strong Problem Statement

Weak

Digital public services are important. Many people use digital services, but there are many problems. Therefore, this study will examine digital services.

Why is it weak?

- ▶ Too general
- ▶ No evidence
- ▶ Problem is unclear
- ▶ No specific population or context
- ▶ No research gap

Better Direction

Identify the specific issue, provide evidence, show what is unknown, and explain why investigation is needed.

Example: Building the Problem Statement

1. Current Situation

Local governments are increasingly using digital platforms to provide public services.

2. Problem

However, access and utilization of these services may vary among citizens.

3. Evidence

Previous studies have identified digital literacy, accessibility, trust, and service quality as relevant factors.

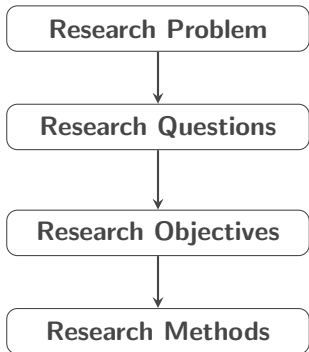
4. Gap

However, evidence may be limited for the selected local-government context.

5. Research Need

Therefore, empirical investigation is required to examine the factors associated with citizens' access to digital public services in the selected context.

Problem → Questions → Objectives



Alignment Principle

The research problem should logically determine what questions are asked and what objectives are pursued.

Example of Alignment

Research Problem

Limited evidence exists regarding the factors associated with citizens' access to digital public services in local governments.

Research Question

What factors are associated with citizens' access to digital public services?

Research Objective

To examine the factors associated with citizens' access to digital public services.

Check

Problem ↔ Question ↔ Objective

Common Problems in Writing Background

1. Starting with a very broad definition.
2. Providing information unrelated to the research problem.
3. Writing many paragraphs without citations.
4. Listing studies without synthesis.
5. Using outdated or weak evidence when better sources exist.
6. Describing the topic but not identifying the problem.
7. Claiming a research gap without reviewing relevant literature.
8. Repeating the same information.
9. Introducing variables that are not connected to the study.
10. Ending the background without clearly establishing the need for the study.

Common Problems in Formulating Research Problems

Weak Practice

“There are many problems.”

“This topic is important.”

“Few studies exist.”

“No research has been done.”

Very broad problem

Problem unrelated to title

Better Practice

Identify the specific problem.

Explain why it is important using evidence.

Specify what has not been adequately studied.

Verify the literature before making the claim.

Define population, context, and scope.

Ensure alignment with title and objectives.

Activity 1: Build Your Background

Using your research title from Session 1, complete:

1. **Broad Context**

What is the larger issue?

2. **Current Situation**

What is happening now?

3. **Study Context**

Where and among whom?

4. **Evidence**

What statistics, reports, or studies support the issue?

5. **Existing Knowledge**

What have previous studies found?

6. **Research Gap**

What remains unclear or insufficiently studied?

Output

Write a **6–8 sentence preliminary background**.

Activity II: Convert Your Background into a Problem

Complete the following statements:

1. The current situation is:
2. The specific problem is:
3. Evidence that the problem exists:
4. What previous studies have not adequately explained:
5. Why the problem matters:
6. Therefore, this study is needed to:

Activity III: Write Your Problem Statement

Using your answers from the previous activity:

1. Combine the current situation and the problem.
2. Add evidence from relevant literature.
3. Explain what is missing or unresolved.
4. Explain why the issue matters.
5. State why further research is required.

Output of the Activity

One preliminary research problem statement

Activity IV: Peer Review

Exchange your background and problem statement with another participant.

Ask your colleague:

1. Is the research topic immediately clear?
2. Does the background move from broad to specific?
3. Are important claims supported by evidence?
4. Can you identify the actual research problem?
5. Is the research gap clearly visible?
6. Does the problem justify the proposed study?
7. Does the problem align with the research title?

Peer Review Test

Can you explain the research problem in **one sentence** after reading the background?

Your Final Output

By the end of this session, you should have:

1. **Research Title**

Your refined title from Session 1.

2. **Background of the Study**

A logically organized preliminary background.

3. **Research Problem**

A clearly stated and researchable problem.

4. **Research Gap**

Evidence showing what remains insufficiently understood.

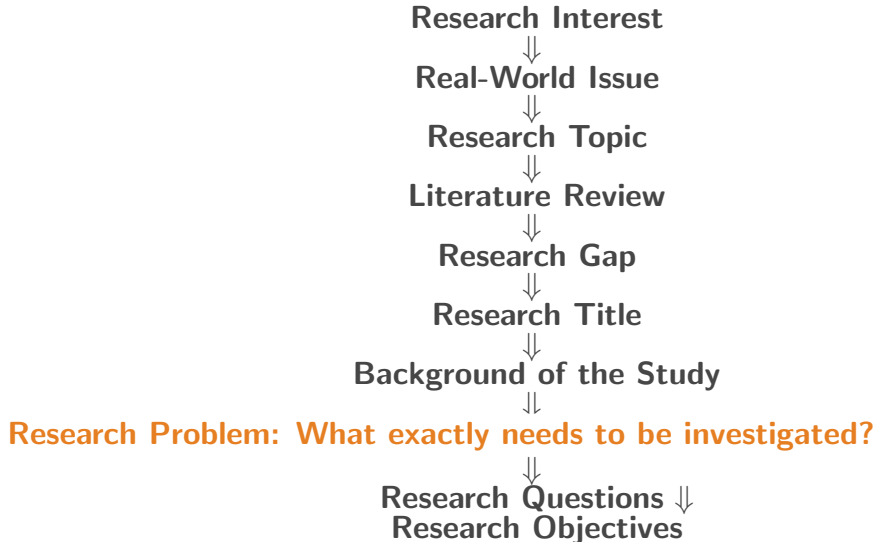
5. **Research Need**

A clear explanation of why the study is required.

Session Output

Title + Background + Research Problem

The Complete Logic of Your Research



Take-Home Message

Do not start writing the background by simply describing the topic.

Start with the research problem.

Use evidence to build the argument.

Narrow the discussion from broad context to specific problem.

Remember

Background $\neq$ Information

Background = Argument leading to the Research Problem

Thank You

Questions and Discussion

A good research problem is the foundation of a good research study.